The AI-Coded Product Check

A 5-MINUTE GUIDED DIAGNOSIS

Why does your product still feel generic, and where should you fix it first? Stop guessing. Run your interface through the Narrative Physics framework.

1. The Signature Moment Score

Does your product have one moment people would actually mention to a friend?

1
Forgettable
Nothing stands out. It works, but it's completely forgettable.

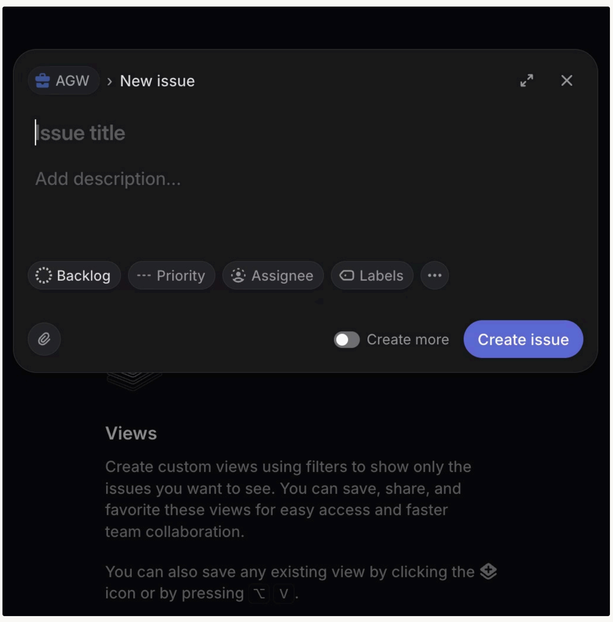
2
Disconnected
One feature is nice, but it's not tied to our brand identity.

3
Forced
There is a clear moment, but it feels forced or purely decorative.

4
Signature
There is a signature interaction that people could describe in one sentence.

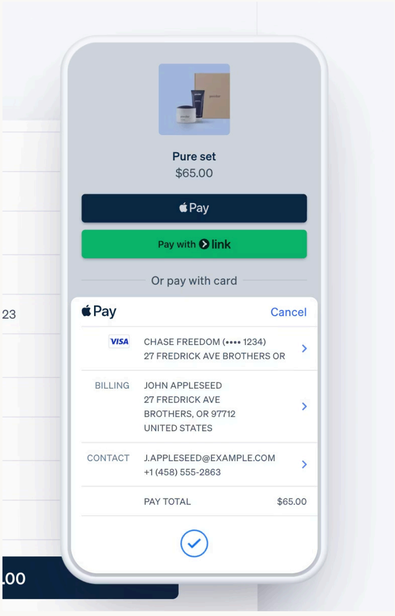
Examples of a "3":

Linear



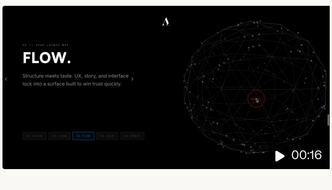
The instant, frictionless feeling of hitting 'C' to create an issue.

Stripe



The exact speed and tension of the success checkmark.

AGNC



YouTube
agnc process

The "Chaos to Orbit" 3D spatial transition.

If you scored a 0 or 1, you don't need a full redesign. You need one signature moment.

2. The Mechanics Menu

Stop borrowing visual aesthetics (glassmorphism, brutalism). Steal cultural mechanics. Pick the one that best matches your product's personality or job. **Pick the mechanic that best matches the emotional job of the interaction you're designing.**

Which mechanic should your product steal? (Circle One)

1– Protect

For moments that need defense, interruption, security, caution, or validation.

Good for: fraud detection • moderation • confirmation barriers • security checks • permissions • blocking risky actions

Your coded translation: Block, shield, counter, intercept

2– Commit

For moments that need tension, intention, buildup, or irreversible release.

Good for: publishing • deleting • sending • launching • booking • confirming something important

Your coded translation: Charge, wind-up, hold-to-release

3– Hit

For moments that need weight, emphasis, consequence, or completion.

Good for: task completion • milestone moments • destructive actions • error states • important confirmations • rewards

Your coded translation: Impact, hit-stop, smash, collision

4– Reveal

For moments that need discovery, payoff, surprise, or information unfolding.

Good for: analytics • results • onboarding reveals • unlocking tiers • recommendations • search results

Your coded translation: Reveal, uncover, flip, peel-back

5– Shift

For moments that need a state change, context switch, immersion jump, or entering a different mode.

Good for: mode switches • section jumps • focus modes • entering creation flow • changing environments • moving from summary → detail

Your coded translation: Warp, transition, portal, domain expansion

6– Link

For moments that need relationship, interconnectedness, system logic, or visible flow.

Good for: CRMs • node tools • workflow automation • ecosystem products • maps • multi-part systems

Your coded translation: Orbit, network, constellation, chain

7– Hum

For moments that need presence when nothing is actively happening.

Good for: idle states • screensavers • dashboards at rest • waiting states • ambient monitoring • branded atmosphere

Your coded translation: Alive at rest, ambient motion, screensaver logic, system heartbeat

Don't invent from scratch. Pick one mechanic and build your next interaction around it.

3. Idle State Test

What happens when nobody is touching your product?

Pick your current level:

[A] Dead Space

Nothing. It just sits there.

[B] Generic Motion

It has some loading spinners or motion, but it feels generic.

[C] Branded Idle

It has a branded idle state or ambient behavior.

[D] Living Environment

Even at rest, it still feels distinctly like our product.

The Diagnosis:

If A:

Your product feels assembled, not crafted.

If B:

You have motion, but not identity.

If C:

You're close. Your idle state has personality.

If D:

Premium territory. Your software feels like a living environment.

4. Your Next Move

Based on your answers, here is exactly where to focus your resources first:

If your Signature Moment Score is 0–1:

Do not rebuild your dashboard. Do not change your typography. Design and ship *one* highly memorable interaction for your most-used feature.

If you don't know what mechanic fits:

Start by picking one from the "Mechanics Menu" above. Translate the timing of that mechanic into your primary button or form state.

If your product feels dead at rest (A or B):

Stop designing dead space. Add an ambient data pulse, a bespoke screensaver, or a branded empty state before adding any new features.

> **Tools are getting easier. Signature moments are the new X-factor.**
>
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